

fridayReview

THE HINDU

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The fundraiser production brought together two dancers and a musician **p2**



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The fabric of dance

On National Handloom Day, a look at how handwoven textiles are giving performances a fresh visual identity

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From Chennai to Canada An Indian Innovation in Knee Replacement Earns Global Recognition

A Space Marketing Initiative

An invitation extended to Dr. Ragunathan Narayanaswamy, Founder & Chief Orthopaedic Surgeon, Rathimed Speciality Hospital, to present his indigenous innovation at the prestigious Personalised Arthroplasty Society (PAS) Annual Meeting in Montreal reflects growing global recognition for an Indian breakthrough in personalised knee replacement.

A Global Honour Rooted in Indian Innovation

Recognition on the global stage is seldom the result of a single breakthrough. More often, it is the culmination of years of clinical experience, scientific research and an unwavering commitment to solving real-world challenges. That journey has now brought Rathimed Speciality Hospital, Chennai, international recognition for its pioneering work in personalised kinematic knee replacement.

Dr. Ragunathan Narayanaswamy has been invited as a guest speaker at the prestigious Personalised Arthroplasty Society (PAS) Annual Meeting in Montreal, Canada—one of the few Indian orthopaedic surgeons to receive this distinction. His presentation will showcase an indigenous surgical innovation developed in Chennai that is helping redefine personalised knee replacement for patients with advanced arthritis. The team's research has also been accepted for presentation at an international arthroplasty conference in China later this year, further reinforcing the global relevance of this work.

Addressing an Indian Clinical Challenge

The hospital's journey into kinematic knee replacement began in 2016 after studying the pioneering work of Dr. Stephen Howell, whose philosophy centred on restoring a patient's natural knee anatomy instead of relying solely on conventional mechanical alignment.

While the concept proved successful, Indian patients presented a unique challenge. Many seek treatment only after advanced arthritis has resulted in severe deformity and bone loss, making it difficult to accurately recreate the knee's original anatomy. Recognising this unmet need, Dr. Ragunathan Narayanaswamy and his team embarked on years of research to develop a solution specifically tailored to Indian patients.

A 'Make in India' Breakthrough

Years of research led to the design, development and clinical validation of precision surgical instruments that accurately recreate the patient's original joint surface, enabling highly precise implant positioning in all three dimensions.

Developed through close collaboration between clinicians and engineers, this indigenous innovation restores the knee's natural kinematics while demonstrating how Indian medical research can solve complex clinical challenges with home-grown technology. More than a surgical advancement, it represents the successful coming together of medicine, engineering and innovation to improve patient care.

Transforming Patient Outcomes

Clinical experience with personalised kinematic knee replacement has shown encouraging outcomes. Patients have experienced reduced pain, less blood loss, faster rehabilitation and improved functional mobility when compared with conventional approaches. By restoring each patient's natural anatomy, the technique aims to deliver a knee that feels and functions more naturally after surgery.

"When we introduced kinematic knee replacement in 2016, many questioned the approach because it challenged conventional thinking. But we believed in the philosophy. As we continued, we saw patients recover faster, experience less pain and blood loss, and achieve better functional outcomes. Every innovation we pursue has only one purpose—to help our patients regain mobility and quality of life."

— Dr. Ragunathan Narayanaswamy



Dr. Ragunathan Narayanaswamy
M.S. (Orth.), DNB Orth., MRCS Edin, FRCS Ortho, CAS (UK)
Consultant Orthopaedic Surgeon, Specialist in Arthroscopy,
Knee Preservation & Knee Replacement Surgery and
Sports Injury Specialist.

For Dr. Ragunathan Narayanaswamy, however, the greatest reward is not international recognition—it is seeing the difference innovation makes to patients.

He recalls the experience of a 70-year-old gentleman who recently underwent his second knee replacement surgery.

"Just three and a half hours after surgery, he was sitting comfortably, smiling and moving both knees without pain. Moments like these remind us why we continue to innovate. Every refinement ultimately translates into a better experience and faster recovery for our patients."

Recognition Beyond Borders

Today, Rathimed Speciality Hospital is also training orthopaedic surgeons in personalised kinematic knee replacement while making its indigenous instruments available for wider adoption. What began as an effort to address a uniquely Indian clinical challenge has evolved into an innovation that is now receiving international recognition.

As this 'Make in India' innovation gains global attention, it stands as an inspiring example of how Indian clinical expertise can contribute meaningfully to the future of orthopaedic surgery worldwide.

Presented as a fundraiser for Aim for Seva, the visually rich production would have benefitted from a fresh take

V.V. Ramani

Piercing cries of “Krishna, Krishna” filled the air as a woman artiste ran across the diagonally lit path on stage. This dramatic opening introduced the protagonist of *Radha*, a fundraiser for Swami Dayananda Krupa Care. Presented by Aim for Seva, it was a collaborative performance featuring dancer-couple Parvathy Menon and Shijith Nambiar, along with flautist Praveen Godkhindi. The show marked its Chennai premiere ahead of its U.S. tour.

The production began with a young Radha playing with her friends. She catches a glimpse of Krishna as a child in his cradle and instantly loses her heart to him. Eager to express her affection, she brings him a gift, only to be disappointed when another girl arrives first each time with an identical offering. Finally, Radha presents him with a peacock feather, which eventually becomes Krishna’s crowning adornment. This charming scene, enacted by young Bhadra S. Menon, laid the foundation for Radha’s love.

What begins as innocent childhood affection gradually blossoms into a lifelong devotion to Krishna. Through the pain of separation and longing, Radha arrives at a moment of self-realisation, questioning whether she is searching for Krishna or for herself through him. This spiritual and emotional journey, culminating in



Grace and resonance Shijith Nambiar and Parvathy Menon; and Pravin Godkhindi. PHOTOS COURTESY: AIM FOR SEVA



among the many sakhis, with the narrative gravitating more towards Krishna Leela.

The dancers impressed with their well-coordinated performances, and the musical contributions of the three guest musicians were commendable. The production sustained its momentum, with each performer playing their part effectively. However, the content lacked the depth needed to weave these elements together.

To elevate the *jugalbandhi* experience to a sublime level, there needed to be more moments of interaction and challenge between the main artistes. However, such moments were few and far between.

The dance ensemble comprised Lakshmi Priya Akkal, S.K. Nayaaroy, Simran Sivakumar and Sreekakshmi E.B. with Bhadra S. Menon and Parvathy Menon as the younger and older Radha, and Shijith as Krishna.

Audience members often travel considerable distances to attend a performance. Keeping them waiting for over an hour beyond the scheduled start time to accommodate the organisers’ fundraising programme is hardly acceptable. It was disheartening to see several people leave before the performance even began, defeating the very purpose of the event.

A familiar Radha

their final union, formed the premise on which the production unfolded.

The flute and Krishna are inseparable, and Pravin Godkhindi’s evocative playing blended seamlessly with the visual narrative. His swara passages in Hamsadhvani, accompanying the intimate scenes, along with renditions of ‘Krishna nee begane baro’ and ‘Chaliye kunjan’ at key moments, enhanced the production’s emotional appeal.

Shijith was appealing as Krishna. The scene in which he discovers a bamboo flute, tentatively attempts to play it, and gradually develops a rapport with the instrument was

particularly engaging. However, better synchronisation between the music and the visualisation would have enhanced its impact.

The rhythmic syllables of the jathi, ‘Taa kuta tati kutta’, rendered powerfully by Anoor Vinod Shyam (mridangam) and Sai Vamshi (Indian percussion), provided the dramatic intensity required for the *Kaliya Narthana* sequence. The choreography was executed with conviction. Equally striking were the abstract peacock-feather imagery in the backdrop and the evocative lighting design by Gyan Dev Singh.

The familiar episodes of ‘Govardhanagiri’ and ‘Raas

Leela’, along with visuals of dancing peacocks and grazing cows, added to the production’s visual appeal. The use of odhnis and ghagras in the costumes, and flowing dupattas as props, further enhanced its visual charm.

Yet, one question arose: while Radha and Krishna have inspired several dance productions over the years, what distinguished this one in terms of concept or presentation? Between the childhood episodes and the final union, there was little exploration of Radha as an individual. As a result, the audience had limited opportunity to connect with her emotional journey. Radha remained largely one



Classical soundscape Delhi Sunderrajan with M.A. Sundareswaran (violin); Tiruvurur Vaidyanathan (mridangam) and K.V. Gopalakrishnan (kanjira); and A. Kanyakumari (below). PHOTOS: SHIVKUMAR PUSHPAKAR AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT.

The closing note

The year-long series on Tyagaraja’s ekaika raga kritis highlighted the joy of exploring the composer’s rare works

a brisk start. A short swara segment capped it. Sunderrajan’s sublime artistry came to the fore in his alapana of Bhushavali, a shadava-sampurna raga (nishada-varja in the ascent) derived from Vachaspathi. He maintained the raga’s identity throughout, with characteristic phrases flowing with elegance. Sundareswaran’s response on the violin was sweet and silken. The vocalist’s rendition of ‘Tanamidane’, a composition in which Tyagaraja owns up to his faults rather than complaining to Rama, made one wonder why it is not heard more often in concerts. Deftly presented kalpanaswaras added value.

The Vasanthabhairavi kriti ‘Nee dayarada’ (in Rupakam) showcased the

beauty of sangatis – with familiar ones in the one-phrase pallavi, and a few intriguing variations rendered in the charanam. Sunderrajan then moved on to Swarabhushani, a rare shadava-shadava raga with an asymmetric scale (omits ‘ri’ in the ascent and ‘ga’ in the descent) derived from

Kharaharapriya, and rendered ‘Varadaraja ninnu kori’, also set in Rupaka tala. Subhaptantuvrali ushered in a reflective mood. Sunderrajan’s exploration of the raga, particularly in the mandhra sthayi, was marked by measured and meditative



phrases. ‘Ennalu urake’ is a typically expressive kriti whose dominant sentiment is one of mock indignation and loving confrontation, born from a deep sense of intimate devotion. Tyagaraja takes on the role of a lawyer presenting a case, questioning the Lord’s apparent indifference by reminding him of his own divine track record. The niraval at ‘Satatamu tyagaraju nammaga leda?’ – the rhetorical question “Didn’t Tyagaraja forever keep faith in you?” – sustained the emotional arc beautifully. The ensuing swara passages sparkled with seamless team sync, the top-octave forays rising

above the rest. ‘Manavyala kincha ratade’ in Nalinakanti and ‘Evvare Ramayya’ in Gangeyabhushani followed, with contrasting musical contours. A short delineation of raga Andolika – whose literal meaning is ‘palanquin’ or ‘swing’ – led into the kriti ‘Raga sudha rasa’, which proved true to the raga’s name. Like a palanquin bearing a sovereign, Andolika lifted the kriti’s theology – sacrifice, union, enjoyment – carrying Tyagaraja’s ecstatic vision of Omkara in a single melodic procession. Synergy was the reigning element in another burst of engaging swara exchanges. Vaidyanathan’s energy and experience were an asset, and his tani avartanam in two-kalai Adi tala alongside his percussion partner Gopalakrishnan was crisp and lively. ‘Kamalaptakula’ in Brindavana Saranga was the concluding composition. On the day, ‘Pavamana’ served as the mangalam not just for the concert, but for the series itself.

Time-tested repertoire

L. Shruti performed for Brahma Gana Sabha’s Aadi Dance Festival

Manasa Vijayalakshme C.

Delhi-based dancer and disciple of senior Kuchipudi artistes Seetha Nagajothy and P. Nagajothy, L. Shruti, presented a solo recital at the Aadi Dance Festival 2026. The Nagajothys, who trained under the legendary Vempati Chinna Satyam, carry forward his illustrious bani.

Shruti, who balanced technique with abhinaya, commenced the recital with ‘Vani ki vandhanam’ – an invocatory piece written and choreographed by Seetha Nagajothy and set to music by K.G. Rupa. Set in Ragamalika and adi tala, the composition invokes goddess Saraswati, celebrating her as the embodiment of all forms of knowledge and art. Shruti’s measured execution complemented the devotional mood of the dance and the concluding sculptural pose, illuminated by a spotlight, created a striking visual moment.

The recital then moved to ‘Koluvaitthiva Rangasaaye’, choreographed by Vempati Chinna Satyam in Mohana raga and Adi tala. It describes the beauty of Lord Ranganatha reclining on Adishesha, where the lyrics convey that even a thousand eyes cannot behold his splendour. The choreography blended intricate jathis and gentle



abhinaya. Shruti negotiated both with confidence and grace.

The mood shifted with Bhamakalapam, an excerpt from the all-time favourite Kuchipudi dance-drama. Choreographed by Vempati Chinna Satyam in Anandabhairavi raga and Misra Chapu tala, the piece offered Shruti the scope to convey the nuances of Satyabhama’s character.

The recital concluded with a Tarangam from Narayana Teertha’s *Krishna Leela Tarangini*, depicting Krishna’s childhood. Choreographed and conceptualised by the Nagajothys, this piece in Ragamalika and Adi tala, culminated in Kuchipudi’s signature brass-plate sequence. Shruti performed intricate footwork to dynamic rhythmic combinations, before concluding with the mangalam.

CALENDAR

Bhavan’s Aadi festival

Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Mylapore, will feature harikatha, musical discourse and villupaattu as part of its ‘Aadi Vizha’ to be held from August 10 to 14, 6.30 p.m., at its main auditorium. Schedule: **August 10:** Nagai Maukundan’s discourse ‘Kandhan Karuna!’; **August 11:** Bharathi Thirumagan’s villupaattu ‘Aadi Kaatril Amman Ula’; **August 12:** Suchitra’s discourse ‘Entha Ruchira rama’; **August 13:** Udayalur Kalyanaraman’s namasankirtanam. The festival concludes on August 14 with Veeramani Raju’s devotional rendition at 6.30 p.m. The event is non-ticketed.

Music workshop

The Music Academy, Madras, has organised a workshop on percussion on August 8, 10 a.m., at the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall. Titled ‘Musical Forms and Rhythmic Response in Carnatic Music’, it will be conducted by mridangam vidwan Thiruvaarur Bakthavathsalam. The programme is organised under the endowment instituted by S.A.K. Durga, in memory of her father S.A. Venkataraman. For registration and other details call 2811 2231 or 2811 5162.



Vocal, veena and venu

Maharajapuram Viswanatha Iyer Trust presents the Vocal Veena Venu festival on August 9 and 11, at Ganamritha Hall, Sambandham Street, Mandaveli. The line up begins with Swathi Sri Krishna’s vocal concert on **August 9** at 9 a.m. Veena recitals by Sowmya (3 p.m.); S.P. Ramh and Pavithra Mahesh (4.15 p.m.) and Mudicondan Ramesh (6 p.m.) will follow. Artistes to perform on **August 11** are: J.B. Sruthisagar (flute, 9 a.m.); Aditi Sudarshan (flute, 3 p.m.); Nagai M. Sudharshan (vocal, 4.15 p.m.) and Prapancham Balachandran (flute, 6 p.m.).

Salutations to the guru

Chaturmasya, which begins on the full moon day of Aashadha month, is celebrated as Guru Purnima or Vyasa Purnima. The four-month observance is a tribute to the guru-sishya parampara. To mark this occasion, Dakshinamnaya Sri Sharada Peetam, Sringeri, has organised ‘Vande Guruparamparam’, a four-day musical tribute at Narada Gana Sabha from August 10 to 13. To be presented with the blessings of Sri Bharati Tirtha Mahasannidhanam and Sri Vidhushekhara Bharati Sannidhanam, each evening begins with a parayanam at 5.30 p.m., followed by concerts and upanyasams. The inaugural day (August 10) features a Shiva Sahasranamam parayanam followed by Ramakrishnan Murthy’s concert and upanyasam by K.S. Maheshwaran Nambutiri. August 11: Vishnu Sahasranamam parayanam; Malladi Brothers (vocal) and L. Sowjanya Kumar (upanyasam). August 12: Lalita Sahasranamam parayanam; Amritha Murali (vocal) and Srivalli Anand (upanyasam). The festival concludes on August 13 with Saundarya Lahari parayanam followed by Sikkil Gurucharan’s concert and upanyasam by Manikanthan.

Tapestry of arts

SRINIDI Trust, in association with Brahma Gana Sabha, presents its 21st art festival from August 7 to 9 at Dakshinamurthy Hall, Mylapore. The line up begins with O.S. Arun and ensemble’s ‘Geeta Yatra’ (today at 6 p.m.) followed by Parvati Ravi Ghantasala’s ‘Krishna Madhuryam’. Day two will begin with the presentation of ‘Impact and Innovation’ award to Narthaki, the online magazine followed by Dummies Drama’s *ThanimAI*. The festival ends with a Pattimandram moderated by Prof. S. Raghuraman at 5.30 p.m. and Bosskey’s ‘Sit Up’ comedy.

Feathered grace

Bridge Academy presents Chitra Nityam Mayuranardhanam 2026 on August 9, 4 p.m. at Rajarathinam Stadium, Egmore. Mayura Nardhanam, one of the pancha nardhanams of the ancient Chitra Nityam tradition, symbolises the grace and beauty of the peacock. This rare dance form has been revived after years of research, with temple dance, performed with rare ragas, talas, and traditional sollukattu. Led by Sumathi, the evening will feature more than 60 Bharatanatyam dancers sketching the image of peacock with their feet. The students of Bridge Academy will perform the Mayuranardhanam along with them.



Daksha Sheth

I come from Ahmedabad, a city that has textiles woven into its very identity, so my love for fabrics is almost inherent. When I began researching my production *Sari*, which celebrates the craftspeople behind our beautiful weaves, it started as an exciting journey of discovery. But it was also deeply moving, and at times heartbreaking, to see how many weavers struggle to sustain traditions that have been passed down through generations. That realisation was one of the reasons I felt compelled to create the production. Since then, I have made it a point to work primarily with natural fibres in my creations. My work places great emphasis on the body and movement, and these materials complement that beautifully, allowing the body to move, breathe and express itself with ease.

Anita Ratnam

August 7 was once associated with the Swadeshi Movement. My mother and maternal grandmother were deeply conscious of textiles. From them, I inherited not only a love for sustainable fabrics but also a flair for experimenting with colours, patterns and styling. This sensibility informs all my works, created in close collaboration with my dear friend, costume designer Sandhya Raman. Conversations with Sandhya often unfold alongside the choreographic process. In ‘Naachiyar Next’, for instance, her use of Madurai’s iconic Sungudi saris was particularly striking. The costumes anchored the work both socially, reflecting Andal’s origins in a poor Brahmin family, and culturally, evoking the milieu of Srivilliputhur. Our dances are rooted in emotion, and the use of Indian colour palettes and textiles does not make them any less contemporary. What matters is that these choices arise from aesthetic and artistic necessity, not tokenism. Dance, after all, is also a way of sustaining our craft traditions.



Chitra Swaminathan



Vaibhav Arekar

In my latest production, ‘Viyog’, which explores humanity’s growing disconnect from Nature, we sourced handloom fabric directly from weavers for the costumes. It was important that the material itself reflected the philosophy of the work. Similarly, in ‘Nama Mhane’, which is about the sants and the abhang tradition, we wanted the costumes to be rooted in authenticity and tradition. Costume designer Sushant Jadhav helped bring that vision to life. What a performer wears is important. A costume is never incidental; it shapes the visual language of a production and deepens its storytelling. While cotton and other natural fabrics can be demanding to maintain, they carry a timeless charm that synthetic materials simply cannot replicate.

Geeta Chandran

I grew up and married into households where a love for handlooms ran deep. When I trained in dance and became a performer, my love for saris, particularly handwoven ones, began to dominate not only my wardrobe but also some of my choreographic works. The unusual colours, textures and designs created by weavers across the country excited me, a passion further fuelled by my collaboration with Sandhya Raman.

Sandhya Raman

For a costume designer like me, silk and cotton were never mere fabrics; they reflected our way of life. Whether it was a sari with a broad border or a narrow one, the occasion often dictated the pattern and colour. The psychology of colour remains deeply embedded in our traditions even today. Time-tested hues such as turmeric yellow, kumkum red and auspicious greens continue to resonate, even as we experiment with pastels and contemporary palettes. A sari, to me, is perhaps the most beautiful garment in the world. Though it essentially is two borders and a pallu, but within that simple structure lies immense beauty and meaning. One end belongs to you, while the other tells a story that extends beyond you. I have worked closely with weavers, embroiderers and printers across India, and I have found an enduring connection between textiles and dance. Who better than a dancer to understand a garment? What a dancer wears is not only inspirational but aspirational. Both dance and weaving are driven by rhythm; there is music in the loom, just as there is rhythm in movement. Increasingly, dancers are giving thought to fabric and styling, understanding that what they wear is not merely decorative but an extension of the artistic narrative. The costume has become as thoughtfully designed as the choreography itself.



BRIGITTE CHATAIGNIER BY ARYAMAN PRASAD



Rukmini Devi: Warp, weft and the visionary

V.R. Devika, the author of the book *Rukmini Devi Arundale - Arts Revivalist and Institution Builder*, believes the increasing use of sustainable fabrics in dance productions today is a result of untiring efforts of numerous craft revivalists and pioneering artists. A staunch handloom sari lover herself, she says, “the seeds of this textile journey in dance were sown by Rukmini Devi. She never viewed any aspect of dance in isolation, least of all costume. Recognising its integral role in storytelling and characterisation in dance dramas, she went so far as to establish an in-house weaving unit at Kalakshetra, both to source the right weaves for her productions and to inculcate in her students an understanding of the many threads that connect our artistic and craft traditions. Her legacy continues to inspire dancers, designers and textile enthusiasts alike.”



Arundhuti Banerjee

What does sexuality sound like in Indian music? The question lay at the heart of *Women, Sexuality and Song*, presented by Royal Opera House, Mumbai, in collaboration with AVID Learning. More than a conventional concert, Shubha Mudgal, joined by Aneesh Pradhan and Sudhir Nayak, wove together music, poetry and storytelling, tracing how beauty, longing, desire, motherhood, shame and resilience have echoed through centuries of India’s literary and musical traditions. Few musicians are as well-equipped to undertake such an exploration as Shubha. During a conversation after the concert, she said the challenge lay in balancing the historical context of these poems with a contemporary woman’s perspective. “As an artiste, whatever I perform is inevitably shaped by my own thoughts, experiences and perspective as a woman. At the same time, these poems belong to a different era, so they have to be understood in the context in which they were written. When I present them today, I interpret them through my own sensibility as a female artiste while remaining faithful to their historical context,” Shubha added. The evening opened with a poem by Goswami Harirai, composed by Shubha in raag Tilak Kamod and Rupak taal. It admires Krishna’s physical beauty through the eyes of a devotee, offering an unusual interpretation of bhakti. “It represents a different shade of

Sense and sensuality

Through the concert *Women, Sexuality and Song*, Shubha Mudgal revisited centuries-old conversations on female desire, identity and artistic expression



Into a woman’s world Shubha Mudgal with Aneesh Pradhan; Sudhir Nayak and Pratibha Singh Baghel. PHOTO COURTESY: ROYAL OPERA HOUSE

devotion that we wanted to explore. The poem was written by a male poet, while the musical composition and its interpretation are mine. So, in that sense, both the male and the female gaze exist within the performance,” she said. The programme then moved into the classical *nakh-shikh* and *saraapa* traditions, literary forms that describe the human body. Through an Urdu composition by 18th-century poet Nazir Akbarabadi, Shubha demonstrated how the female

body became a subject of elaborate poetic imagination. The exploration continued with a verse by Badrinarayan Chaudhary’s ‘Premghan’, introducing the audience to the layered meanings of the word *joban*. While literally translating to youth, the word has also been used in poetry as a metaphor for the youthful breasts of young maidens, revealing how desire in classical verse often found expression through subtle metaphor rather than explicit imagery.

Later, the focus shifted from how poets wrote about women to how women expressed themselves through songs. North Indian folk traditions emerged as repositories of lived experience, preserving stories of patriarchy, social expectations, longing and resilience. One folk composition, drawn from Awadhi Lok Geet, confronted the harsh realities of infertility through the story of a woman rejected because of the stigma attached to childlessness. Shubha said, “Social change is never linear. It is often one step

forward, two steps back, and yet the journey continues. The system is still largely patriarchal, and many of these practices are deeply rooted.” Shubha spoke about the taboo infertility carried and the social and emotional humiliation an infertile woman had to endure simply because she could not bear children. “Today, when I perform this song, audiences don’t laugh. Instead, they empathise with the woman. That, to me, is a sign that society is changing, even if slowly.” Shubha also revisited Praveen Rai’s work, the accomplished musician and poet from the court of Orchha’s king Indrajit, celebrated for her brilliance yet burdened with the derogatory label *paatur*. The performance returned to Ratnavali, remembered largely as the wife of Goswami Tulsidas. By pairing verses from Tulsidas’s *Janaki Trijata Samvaad* with Ratnavali’s own *dohas*, the programme restored attention to a poet whose voice has long remained overshadowed. The repertoire also featured poems that challenged patriarchal practices. Shubha recalled one composition in which a woman asks, “If I am the one who bears the pain of childbirth, then why should the child be called his father’s son? Shouldn’t he be our son? She goes to every member of the family, but no one is willing to consider her view. Finally, her husband agrees to his wife’s perspective.” The most thought-provoking inclusions was 18th-century Rekhti poetry, centred on feminine desire and, at times, same-sex love. Historically marginalised because of its homoerotic themes, it gradually disappeared from mainstream performance traditions. “Today, when we are talking about inclusion in society, I feel Rekhti should also be included in the performance,” Shubha said, noting that the genre was largely written by male poets adopting feminine voices. *Women, Sexuality and Song*, revealed itself to be more than just a musical recital. It was a thoughtful exploration of the many ways women have been admired, desired, judged, silenced and remembered across India’s literary and musical traditions. “Even after all these years of being a performing artiste and after seeing so much in life, I still live with the hope that art can bring about change. I believe it has the power to influence the way we think,” she said. For her, the impact of art lies in these quiet transformations. “If, after this performance, someone goes back home and finds that their thinking has changed, even if only a little, or they leave with a sense of hope, then I feel I have done what I set out to do as an artiste.”

I still live with the hope that art can bring about change. I believe it has the power to influence the way we think.

SHUBHA MUDGAL
Hindustani vocalist

Hands Heritage



Siddhi Nawar

Jheeni jheeni beeni chadari-ya..."so finely, finely woven, this sheet." How many of us have heard or sung this line, without knowing it once belonged to a loom?

It's a five-hundred-year-old song written by Kabir, the mystic-poet who was, before anything else, a weaver in Varanasi. He sang it while working, comparing the body to cloth stretched across a frame, and the soul to something returned unblemished to its maker. Singers across the country still perform it today, in classical concerts and temple courtyards alike. What started as one weaver's private hum turned into one of India's most enduring devotional songs. The loom, clearly, was never a silent machine.

Long before "handloom" became a label stitched into your favourite kurta or saree, it was a rhythm handed down from one throat to the next, one loom to the next. The shuttle rarely moves alone, listen carefully and etched beyond the tapestry, you'll notice a tune following closely behind it.

Across India's weaving belts, music does more than accompany the craft. It keeps time for it, keeps memory for it, and keeps the weaver company through the hours.

In Varanasi, weavers still hum devotional verses from Kabir's own tradition while working the pit loom, songs their grandfathers sang to get through long, breathless shifts.

In Kanchipuram, closer to home, weaving is rarely solitary. Whole families, children and grandparents included, work and sing through each stage of a silk saree.

In Pochampally, the count of threads in an ikat pattern often follows a chant, part song and part arithmetic, so hands and voice keep the same beat.

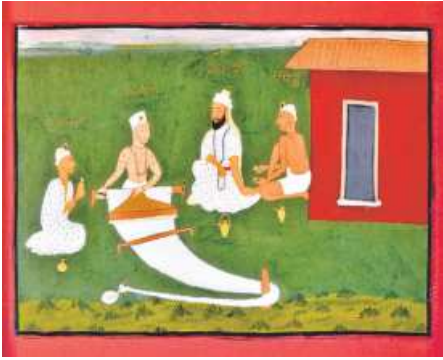
In Chanderi, older women still sing wedding and harvest songs while winding yarn, tucking a village's memory into every skein.

None of this is performance. It's how a weaver survives ten-hour stretches at the loom without the mind going numb, and how a story outlives its teller. Ask why they hum what they hum, and you rarely get folklore in return. You get their own life instead: a mother's lullaby, a migration, a wedding remembered by the song sung the week it happened.

But the hum is fading. Younger weavers increasingly work in silence, earphones in, scrolling between throws of the shuttle. Migration to cities has broken the chain of who sings to whom. And the greatest shift that has influenced it all; Machine looms that don't require company. They don't tire, and they don't remember.

What survives, for now, travels the old way, by breath rather than by book. Every handloom garment you own carries, somewhere in its weave, a few bars of a song that was never written down. World Handloom Day isn't only about celebrating the fabric. It's about pausing to actually listen to the hands that made it, and the tunes that taught them how.

The song
THAT THE
hands
dance to



On National Handloom Day, we take a look at the songs that have kept India's looms company for centuries, and why the hum passed down through generations of weavers is slowly falling silent.



COTTON HOUSE in SHOPPING THIRUVIZHA
தரமான கலகஷன்ஸ், குறைந்த விலையில்!

ஆடி அட்காசம்
எப்போதும் குறைந்த விலையில்!

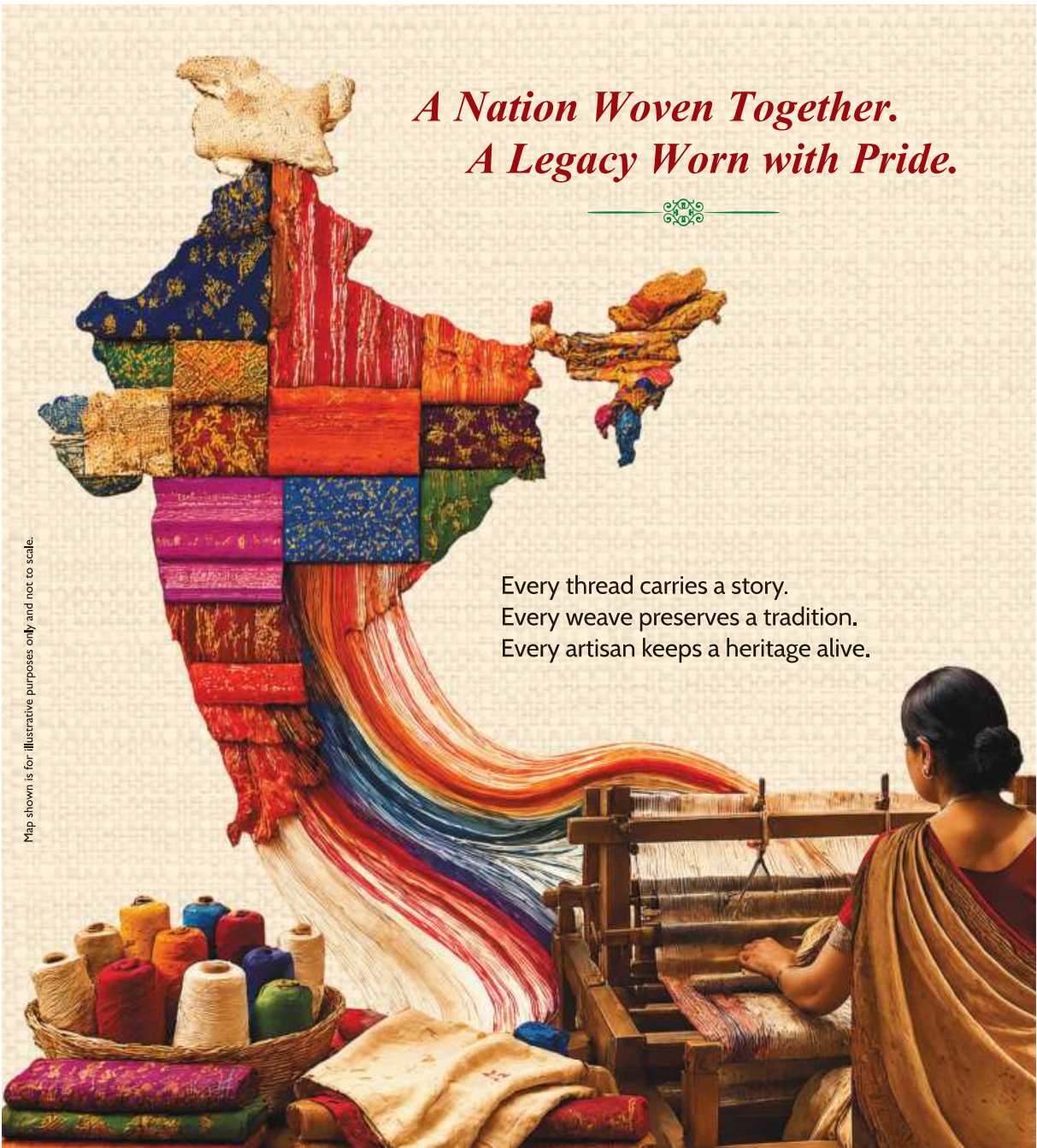
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